



Mental Health



Chronic Pain



Trauma



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When the Mind-Body Breaks: Lee Vaughan's Journey Through Pain, Trauma, and Transformation

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From the Heartache of His Father's Sudden Death to Enduring Emotional Pain and Conquering the UK Coast Cycling Challenge

Beginnings of Persistent Pain

My journey with persistent pain began when I was just 10 years old. While I wasn't in constant pain at that age, life events soon began to shape who I would become and the path I would follow.

Persistent pain isn't something anyone would choose — why would we? It's a battle that chooses us, and it's undeniably unfair.

We understand that pain serves a purpose: it alerts us to injury, harm, or danger. But when pain lingers, it can stop being helpful, often failing to reflect what's really happening in our bodies.

Sometimes, pain stems from physical events, like the time I jumped high — channeling Peter Shilton — to deflect an imaginary shot over an invisible crossbar, only to land hard on a large rock acting as a goalpost.



That injury to my coccyx didn't just last a lifetime; it set off a chain reaction in my nervous system, which had been waiting for its moment to communicate with me

Early Trauma and Its Lasting Impact

On March 23rd, 1984, my father suddenly collapsed at home. He died instantly from a massive heart attack, right there on our living room floor. There were no goodbyes, just the sound of his body hitting the ground — a thud that remains my last memory of him.

The 80s were a different time, and my father's family, tough as nails, resembled a Sheffield version of the Peaky Blinders. At my father's funeral, as my grandmother tried to console me, she placed her hand on my knee and said,

“Lee, you are the man of the house now.” A sentence that has haunted me for years. Looking back, I can’t help but think, what a thing to say to a 10-year-old boy?

My poor mum, only 37 at the time, widowed with two young boys, was offered little comfort. The authorities told her she was too young to claim widow’s benefits. Her grief quickly turned into a downward spiral, leaving her overwhelmed before we had even returned to school. I’ll never forget the moment she knelt in front of me, her face etched with sorrow, and told me, “Lee, your dad died tonight.” That image is seared into my memory — a psychological photograph I will carry forever.

That night, I lost both my parents. My mum was never the same again, her spirit crushed by grief.

At school, I spent years hiding the fact that I no longer had a dad. In Spanish class, I would shrink in my chair, praying the teacher wouldn’t ask me anything about him. For five years, I kept it a secret, never fully understanding why.

In my late teens, pain became a constant companion. A goalkeeping accident seemed to trigger it, breaking through the fragile defenses that had shielded me throughout childhood.

Marital Struggles and Mental Health Crisis

Later in life I married, and we had two children, however my wife suffered a severe mental health breakdown in the months preceding our second child’s birth. We were financially ruined and very few people took the time to understand the complexity and painful nature of the situation. The system failed us whilst social services loomed ever closer. I quit my career as a financial advisor and became a full-time carer for my wife and children. During this period, I was pushed to the darkest places of mental health struggles. At the time I thought I could never be pushed to such psychological extremes ever again. Surely by now I had paid enough forwards?

My life became one of physical pain and chronic fatigue, symptoms nobody and no scans could explain.

Living with Invisible Pain

At 28, I had hip surgery to replace my severely damaged right hip, believing it would end my constant pain. While the hip pain disappeared, it was replaced by even more widespread and intense pain, affecting more areas of my body and severely disrupting my daily life.

As the years passed, the pain grew louder, yet still, no one could explain why. How could I hurt so much with no clear reason? All I wanted was to be “fixed.” Most of my appointments with healthcare providers involved me staring at the backs of their heads as they printed out yet another prescription. I kept hearing the same phrase, over and over again: “It’s just something you’ll have to learn to live with.”

After finally getting an MRI, my GP called a few days later. When they started listing terms like C1, C2, L4, L5, and words like “compression” and “degeneration,” I knew the cause had been found. I thought to myself, “I’ll be in a wheelchair in five years,” and began living as if that was inevitable.

Words matter when talking to someone in pain. Describing disc degeneration as “a pack of crumbling biscuits” only makes things worse. Pain often feels predictive, and hearing Peter O’Sullivan discuss “healthcare-induced disability” helped me realize how deeply language shapes our coping strategies.

Trauma and Pain Escalation

After a serious car accident in my 30s, I went to my GP with pain throughout my body. In hindsight, it’s clear that such a traumatic event pushed my already-overloaded nervous system to a new level. When I tried explaining this, my GP dismissed it with, “Oh, I see... everything hurts, does it?” His tone made it clear I wasn’t believed, and he added, “You know I can’t influence an insurance claim, right?” Despite a history of trauma and pain dating back to my teens, my suffering was dismissed as an insurance scam.

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By my 40s, I realized my Financial Services career wasn't fulfilling me. My anxiety skyrocketed, and I became obsessed with my heart health. Reaching 40 became a painful milestone, a trigger that intensified my pain and fatigue.

In 2019, while working as a Leisure Centre Manager, I was exposed to a traumatic event so horrific that the attending Police Sergeant called it the worst of his 30-year career. I won't go into details, but it was a night that haunted me deeply. I discovered the body of a 27-week-old baby. I returned to work the next day, despite having been at the crime scene until early morning. The offered counseling was inadequate, and my employer provided no further support. Meanwhile, the Police Sergeant received extensive counseling from South Yorkshire Police.

Soon after, the Covid-19 pandemic hit, and the isolation only deepened the emotional repression I had been struggling with. Looking back, it's clear how everything compounded in ways I couldn't fully understand at the time.

Breaking Down and Finding Hope

By November 2021, I had become unrecognizable. I was taking 28 tablets a day just to function, but I was far from functional. Filled with rage and lacking empathy, I had become a ticking time bomb, still working in the same building where the trauma had occurred — a trauma that had been simmering, waiting to erupt.

People lost their jobs due to my actions, and my employer tried every way to remove me from my role.

By January 2022, I had mentally and physically broken down. I was signed off work, drowning in excruciating pain, with the 28 tablets only clouding my mind. At 47, I had given up on ever returning to work.

My cabinet was full of drugs — Gabapentin, Nefopam, Codeine, Naproxen, Sertraline, Omeprazole — but they offered no relief. Instead, I felt like I was holding a loaded gun to end the pain. My healthcare providers suggested morphine as the next step.

A Turning Point: Changing My Understanding of Pain



So what changed? My understanding of pain changed.

A brilliant psychologist with the Sheffield Pain Management Programme simply allowed me a safe space to share my story — my pain. She described me as “the meat between two dogs” and this made so much sense. She was also the first person to ever suggest to me that my pain experience could be linked to emotional trauma. It was done very subtly and with a great deal of empathy — but she planted a seed.

About a year later I was now educating myself daily about Pain Science and I was becoming increasingly more active in self-care. On one of my weekly walks, I was listening to a podcast between Rangan Chatterjee and Howard Schubinar. In the podcast Howard spoke the following sentence, a sentence which would change my life

“Physical Trauma and Emotional Trauma share the same neural pathway in the brain”

This sentence poured water on the seed planted about a year earlier and also on the fire that burned inside me. Of course, this was ‘my explanation’ for my pain. It just made perfect sense. If emotional trauma can be responsible for a physical experience of pain, then this was the end of my 30 year wait for an explanation.

Embracing Pain as a Guide

Today I still have pain in my life, but it is no longer my life. I don’t aspire to be pain free because I accept it into my life. Pain has become the friend that I have needed to alert me to my emotional triggers — the triggers the 10-year-old boy within me began collecting all those years ago.



The Flippin’ Pain tour rode across some of the most challenging terrain the UK can throw at cyclists, and we covered approximately 200 miles in 5 days.

Giving Back: Becoming a Lived Experience Advocate

Now my recovery journey involves giving back as a Lived Experience Advocate. People with Biopsychosocial visions value my worth and I am now working as a

Health Coach in the NHS, delivering Pain Education at Pain Cafés in Sheffield. I also work as a Pain Educator with Pain Concern UK hosting online pain education workshops for people living with persistent pain.



Peak Health Coaching in Sheffield have recruited me as an associate within the organisation. With the likes of Dr. Ollie Hart, Dr. Tim Williams and Dr. Deepak Ravindran I now deliver Pain Education to Health Care Professionals and it's powerful.

A Community of Support

I also host a Facebook Group designed to provide Peer to Peer support. It has become such a wonderful place to be part of. A community of people with shared experiences willing to help guide and support one another.

Every day of my life now I live with the security of having my own “Flare Kit”. Having self management strategies that I know are effective for me, serves to lessen my fear of pain. I have learned to listen to the messages from my body and accept them as the “parking sensors” of my life.



For over 33 years, I have navigated the challenges of living with Persistent Pain. While it continues to be a part of my life, I've reached a point where it no longer defines me. My pain may not have been visible to others, but had someone taken the time to listen, my story could have revealed a deeper understanding of my experience. Today, I want to share that journey, shedding light on the complexities of living with pain and the strength it takes to rise above it.

C.S. Lewis once said “you can’t go back and change the beginning, but you can start where you are and change the ending”.

Hope Heals

Lee

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Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.
